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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (Honours), July 2026 Third SEMESTER Value Addition Course (VAC)

MG3VACENG201 **- LITERATURE, TECHNOLOGY AND AI** (2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 1 Hour 30 Minutes Maximum Marks: 50

Scheme of Valuation

Part A – MCQ

Answer all questions Each question carries 1 mark

1. b. Generation Alpha K (CO1)
2. c. Touch and direct speech U(CO2)
3. b. Community and creativity exist beyond apps. An (CO3)
4. b. Manual K (CO2)
5. b). LongPen U(CO3)

[1x5 = 5]

Part B

Answer any 6 questions. Each question carries 5 marks

6. The essay "Virtual is the New Digital" highlights Gen Z's (Virtual Natives') outlook- prompting previous generations to rethink how we approach life, work, and leisure, and to locate the true value at the centre of many processes. Millennials experienced several economic crises like the Great Recession of 2008. In 2019, it was calculated that Millennials earn 20% less than the Boomers did at the same age, and live with daily anxiety levels about the loss of a job. Gen Z-no concern for careers- as no guarantee of a stable career future. They use digital tools, platforms and services in order to restore life control that they perceive the Millennials lost. K(CO1)

7. In *"The Murderer"* by Ray Bradbury, Brock portrays technology as an invasion of privacy- showing how electronic devices constantly intrude into every aspect of his personal life. Communication devices make him permanently accessible, with telephones and other electronic systems interrupting his peace at all hours. Brock feels that machines have taken control of his life, deciding what he hears, sees, and experiences, leaving him with little personal freedom. His violent rejection of the machines symbolizes his desire to reclaim privacy and human freedom. An(CO2)

8. E.K. Kamalakshan Nair, of Sethu's "Password", a retired teacher of Makkattusseri Upper Primary School who belonged to an yester generation- who couldn't think placing him out of Elumbilasseri Veedu, Kunnasseri Village, Makkattusseri Post office- The naming held the tags of the habits of their community bearing the traditions of ancestors- Kamalakshan Nair thought of identity and address as a fixed entity which he lived all his life and perplexed how his son who's miles way could make a new address for him. U(CO3)

9. In *The Machine Stops*, people live in isolated, underground hexagonal rooms equipped with buttons that provide all necessities through the Machine. This self-contained environment eliminates the need for travel or direct human interaction, making the inhabitants completely dependent on technology and cut off from the natural world. K(CO2)

10. A third space -social place outside one's home, workplace, or school where people interact, relax, and build communities. In *"Virtual is the New Digital,"* Catherine D. Henry and Leslie Shannon explain that social media has become the third space for Virtual Natives. These users socialise, collaborate, learn, and express their identities through virtual platforms. Thus, for Virtual Natives, social media is not merely a digital tool but an important social space where meaningful relationships and experiences are formed. K(CO1)

11. In Margaret Atwood's essay "Are Humans Necessary?", the fictional robot Hugo from "The Perfect Servant" represents the limitations of early literary robots. Although they were efficient and obedient, they lacked the emotional intelligence, creativity, and moral awareness that define human beings. U(CO3)

12. In E. M. Forster's *The Machine Stops*, travel by air-ship is presented as a safe, silent, and highly advanced form of transportation. The air-ships fly smoothly above the earth and allow people to travel long distances with ease. In Vashti's time, physical travel has become unusual because people live alone in underground cells and depend entirely on the Machine for communication, education, entertainment, and daily needs. Direct human contact and visits are considered unnecessary and even undesirable due to humans' overdependence on Machines. U(CO2)

13. "Password" symbolizes a shift from the root identity to an arbitrary code- Elumbilasseri Karunakaran Kamalakshan Nair bears generational meanings while the new password is a hollow entity. The shift from the tangible aerograms which were the prized possessions of Aruna which stand as a testimony of Niteesh's success. The password comes as a foreign thing which demands memory - Aruna fears, "What if we forget the password?"-denies permanence and lineage- Password becomes mandatory to get connected to their son, but at the cost of rootedness and inherited identity. An(CO3)

14. Yuval Noah Harari in his essay “Why Technology Favours Tyranny” mentions ordinary people’s habit of managing data that may promote concentration of all wealth and power in the hands of a small elite. Ordinary people currently manage their data passively — accepting terms of service, adjusting app permissions, and occasionally deleting data — but individually they have little real power against large corporations such as Google and Facebook that harvest data. Nationalisation of data by governments could offer one solution and curb the power of big corporations. U(CO2)

[5x6 = 30]

Part C - ESSAY
Answer any 1 question. Each question carries 15 marks

15. Vashti, in E.M. Forster’s “The Machine Stops”, lives in total dependence on the Machine — no human contact, air, light, and even ideas — her son Kuno insists that she visit him in person, rejecting the Machine's mediated version of connection. Her journey exposes how deeply "advanced" humanity has come to fear direct experience, as she reacts with horror to sunlight, smell, and human touch. Unlike other rooms, Kuno's room symbolises resistance. He questions the Machine's authority and longs for freedom. His room becomes a place where independent thought survives, contrasting with the Machine's blind worship and foreshadowing its destructive power. Kuno confesses to Vashti that he escaped to the Earth's surface and discovered that the outside world is still habitable. In the end, Vashti and Kuno

are reunited as the Machine collapses, recognising that humanity's blind faith in technology has led to its downfall. An(CO2)

16. Ray Bradbury exaggerates the sheer saturation of communication technology in “The Murderer” — offices piped with clashing soundtracks, a house that talks in every room, and a bus full of commuters narrating their location to spouses — satirising how "convenience" has metastasised into constant noise. Brock's reactions are levelled up to comic gestures (bite a wrist radio in half, shoot a television six times, and spoon ice cream into a car radio transmitter, turning ordinary appliance)-hatred into absurd, dramatic "murders" that expose the disproportionate grip these devices hold over daily life. Through ‘anthropomorphism’- the front door that "shrills," the stove that "screams," — Bradbury depicts machines as living tyrants, making Brock's violence feel like self-defence rather than vandalism, which sharpens the critique of how technology has usurped human agency. The image of the psychiatrist absorbed into a barrage of ringing phones— after diagnosing Brock as "disoriented" — delivers Bradbury's sharpest exaggeration and irony: society is so completely saturated by devices that even the man meant to cure obsession is himself trapped by it, showing the addiction to be systemic rather than individual. An(CO2)

17. Naomi Kritzer's story "Better Living Through Algorithms"-Apps intervenes human life with trivial things like drinking coffee- spreads the hold to meal planning, wardrobe- a "phone tree" is designed recruiting users to enforce compliance on others-creates conviniences- Abelique, the App deduces Linnea's suppressed interest in art from closet photos- deduces Keith's managerial status from permission- authority becomes personal and powerful. Abelique refuses to help Keith exploit it for workplace productivity-University research reframes it as happiness experiment, not corporate control- but later, users become reliant on imposed structure, App is exploited by spammers, algorithmic trust is questioned-Linnea's invitation to a stranger to paint,shows the shifting authority to individual- Kritzer suggets that algorithmic authority turns dangerous when it makes itself uncecessary.
An(CO3)

[15x1 = 15]